INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #33 · WORK AND AUTHORITY

“People in authority can't be trusted.”

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Where it often comes from

If a parent, teacher, coach, pastor, or boss abused or betrayed authority, the lesson may stay: authority means danger. We may bristle at supervision, expect to be used, or avoid anyone who has power over us. Real experiences of misuse of power deserve to be taken seriously.

What Scripture teaches

The Bible shows both sides. Paul writes, “Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which is from God.” Yet when the council ordered the apostles to stop speaking, Peter and the other apostles replied, “We must obey God rather than men.” The psalmist says, “It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man.” And “The king’s heart is a waterway in the hand of the LORD; He directs it where He pleases.” Authority is not always safe, and it is not always unsafe. We can trust God ultimately, and trust people in proportion to their character.

> *“It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in princes”* (Psalm 118:8–9).

Also see

> “The king’s heart is a waterway in the hand of the LORD; He directs it where He pleases” (Proverbs 21:1).

> “Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which is from God. The authorities that exist have been appointed by God” (Romans 13:1).

> “But Peter and the other apostles replied, ‘We must obey God rather than men.’” (Acts 5:29).

> “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight” (Proverbs 3:5–6).

Common self-statements

- Anyone with power will misuse it.
- They will use me and then drop me.
- I cannot rely on bosses or leaders.
- If I submit, I will be hurt.
- I have to protect myself from them.
- Authority is dangerous.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralizing: Treating every authority as the one who hurt me.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing authorities are either totally safe or totally dangerous.
- Mind reading: Assuming bad motives.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling wary and concluding that all authority is dangerous.

Challenging questions

- Who in authority hurt or betrayed me, and what happened?

- Have any people in authority treated me fairly or kindly?
- How can I tell a trustworthy leader from an unsafe one?
- What does Scripture say about obeying God over people when they conflict?
- How might distrust affect my work and relationships?
- What would healthy, measured trust look like?

Truth summary

> Some people in authority have misused their power, and my caution makes sense. Not all are the same. I can trust God above all, and I can extend trust to people in proportion to their character, with wise boundaries.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Citizenship
- Protection
- Wisdom
- Persecution

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "People in authority can't be trusted"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"People in authority can't be trusted." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who hurt me?
- ☐ Who has been fair?
- ☐ What signs show a safe leader?
- ☐ When do I obey God over people?
- ☐ What does measured trust look like?
- ☐ Who can support me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My ultimate trust is in the Lord.
- ☐ God directs hearts where He pleases.
- ☐ Not every authority is unsafe.
- ☐ I can obey God over people when they conflict.
- ☐ Trust can be measured.
- ☐ I can protect myself wisely.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 118:8–9**
  "It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in princes."
- ☐ **Proverbs 21:1**
  "The king's heart is a waterway in the hand of the LORD; He directs it where He pleases."
- ☐ **Acts 5:29**
  "But Peter and the other apostles replied, 'We must obey God rather than men.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Measured trust: Each week, note one interaction where you gave measured trust and what happened.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 118:8–9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I take refuge in the Lord first, and I can trust people carefully.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Tell your story. Write what happened with the authority who hurt you.
- ☐ List trustworthy qualities. Write signs of safe leadership, such as honesty, consistency, and humility.
- ☐ Test small. Extend small trust to someone who shows these qualities.
- ☐ Get support. Talk to a counselor if your experiences involved abuse.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "People in authority can't be trusted": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Measured trust
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~People in authority can't be trusted.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, some who held authority over me hurt me. Heal that wound. Teach me to trust You above all and to discern who is safe. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.